BREAKING STEREOTYPES

JUSTICE HIMA KOHLI'S MOTHER, who passed away last month, loved novels by American lawyer and author Erle Stanley Gardner, which were largely based on criminal cases and court dramas. It was those books that first kindled the young Hima's interest in courtroom life.

In a judicial system that has long faced criticism for promoting nepotism and being a male-dominated space, Justice Kohli has broken multiple stereotypes. On January 7, 2021, she became the first woman chief justice of the Telangana High Court after it was split from the Andhra Pradesh and Telangana HC in 2019. Seven months later, she was elevated to the Supreme Court, the only one of 11 women judges who made it to the top court.

ACCOMPLISHMENT

In 2021, Kohli was sworn in as the first woman chief justice of the Telangana HC, and in the same year, she became one of the only 11 women judges who have made it to the Supreme Court

A strong advocate of women's empowerment, Justice Kohli has always emphasised creating opportunities for women. "In the judiciary, whether at the higher echelons in the Supreme Court and the high courts or at the district level, women have been successfully negotiating around being women and judges at the same time," she said at a public event recently. On another occasion, she talked about the importance of addressing gender bias in the intellectual property rights space.

The honourable justice is an alumna of Delhi's St Stephen's College and did her post-graduation in history from Delhi University. Despite her father's objections, she went on to pursue a law degree. In 1984, she got registered as an advocate with the Delhi Bar Council, became an Additional Judge of the Delhi HC in 2006 and, a year later, was sworn in as a permanent judge.

As a judge, Kohli has stood firmly for public welfare. During her time at the Delhi HC, she presided over several cases, including ordering inquiries into the detention of prisoners who had already been granted bail and protecting the identity of juveniles. In 2020, she led a panel that monitored the Delhi government's response to the Covid-19 pandemic and censured the Centre as well as the Indian Council for Medical Research for not allowing private laboratories to conduct testing.

In the SC, she has been part of several important cases, such as the dispute between Amazon and Future Retail, same-sex marriage rights, disqualification of Maharashtra MLAs and the tussle between the Delhi government and the L-G. ■

-Kaushik Deka



ANI

Justice Hima Kohli, *64*
Judge, Supreme Court of India

ON GENDER BIAS IN IPR

"It is time for us to look through the gendered lens, stand up for women's intellectual property rights and send a powerful message to the world"

–at a Delhi HC event in Apr. 2023

DESTINY'S OTHER PLANS

Initially, Hima Kohli had enrolled in Delhi University's law course so she could access the library to prepare for the civil services examination. But she started enjoying legal studies, and went on to pursue a law degree despite her father's objections